

Proposal for Emoji Darkling Heart

Submitter: Brian McManus

Date: June 12, 2026

1. Identification.

- a. **Keywords:** dark, gloomy, bittersweet, shadowy, gothic, brooding, melancholy, darkling, blackhearted
- b. **Category:** Smileys & Emotion > heart. Proposed to follow broken heart.

2. Images:

Color 72×72	B&W 72×72	Color 18×18	B&W 18×18
			

- a. I affirm willingness to execute the Unicode Emoji Proposal Agreement and License (<https://unicode.org/emoji/emoji-proposal-agreement.pdf>) upon submission. The example images provided herein are original sample works for illustration, derived from existing Microsoft icons with color changes.

3. Factors for Inclusion

- a. Expresses Multiple Concepts
 - Dark or brooding love
 - Bittersweet or melancholic emotion – love tinged with sorrow
 - Glamorous Goth
 - Just a *touch* of darkness
 - Dark but fun
- b. Can be used with other emoji to convey additional concepts
 - Darkling Heart + Red Rose: gothic romance / dark passion
 - Darkling Heart + Books: dark romance reading (popular book genre, 2025–2026 YTD)

- Darkling Heart + Chains: intense, captivating love, such as “I wish I knew how to quit you,” from *Brokeback Mountain* or “Chains, my baby's got me locked up in chains” – from the R&B song written by Gerry Goffin and Carole King

c. Breaks new ground

- This proposal was inspired by Merriam-Webster pointing out that darkle is a rhyming near-antonym of sparkle that has a distinct meaning
<https://www.instagram.com/merriamwebster/p/DZfVlSqlXxf/?hl=en>
- The Black Heart emoji and the Sparkles emoji may be used in sequence, but we submit that a unified icon expresses an emotion of darkness mixed with light that is not currently represented by a single existing emoji
- The Sparkling Heart's doppelganger

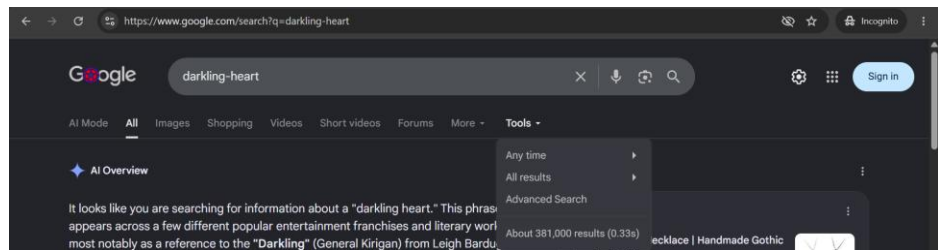
d. Is legible and visually distinctive

- Takes the visual imagery users are already familiar with from Sparkling Heart, Sparkles, and Black Heart to communicate new concepts that are instantly legible and differentiated

e. Has a high usage level

- It does not have “elephant” levels, or search results similar to recently approved emojis like the treasure chest.
- There is an interesting uptick in Ngram for “darkle” at the end of the time series, perhaps influenced by growing literary popularity of the dark romance genre in recent years as noted in Circana BookScan, though the Ngram viewer stops at 2022
 1. “Another Year of Romance with a Dark Twist.” 2025.
<https://www.circana.com/post/another-year-of-romance-with-a-dark-twist-circana-bookscan-reports>
- Frequency (*provide evidence with numbers*)
 1. Google Search
Search: darkling-heart: 381,000 results
URL:

<https://www.google.com/search?q=darkling-heart>

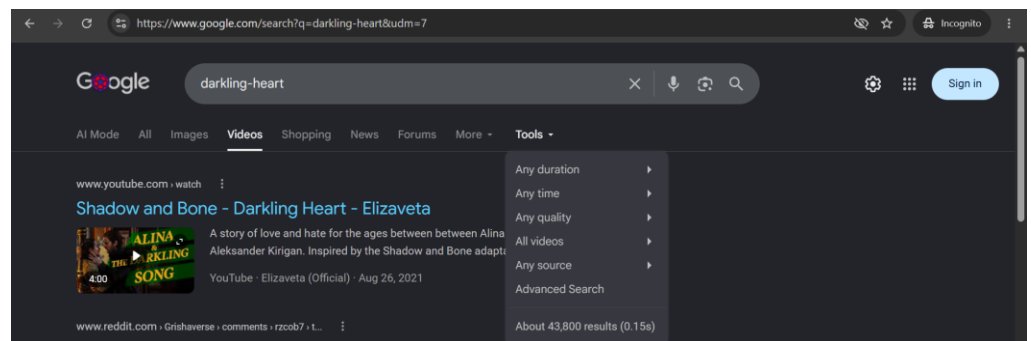


2. Google Video Search

Search: darkling-heart: 43,800 results

URL:

<https://www.google.com/search?tbm=vid&q=darkling-heart>

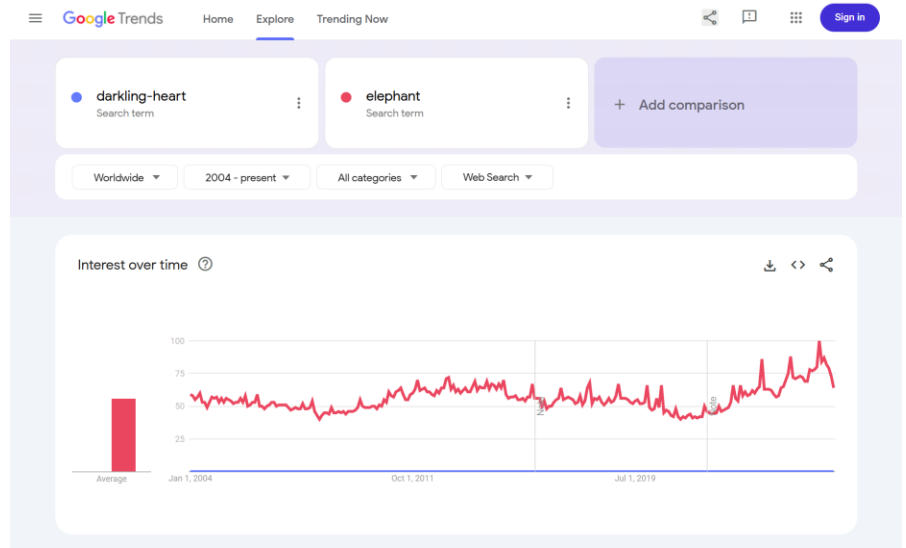


3. Google Trends: Web Search

Search: darkling-heart, elephant — All time: trampled by the elephant!

URL:

<https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all&q=darkling-heart,elephant>

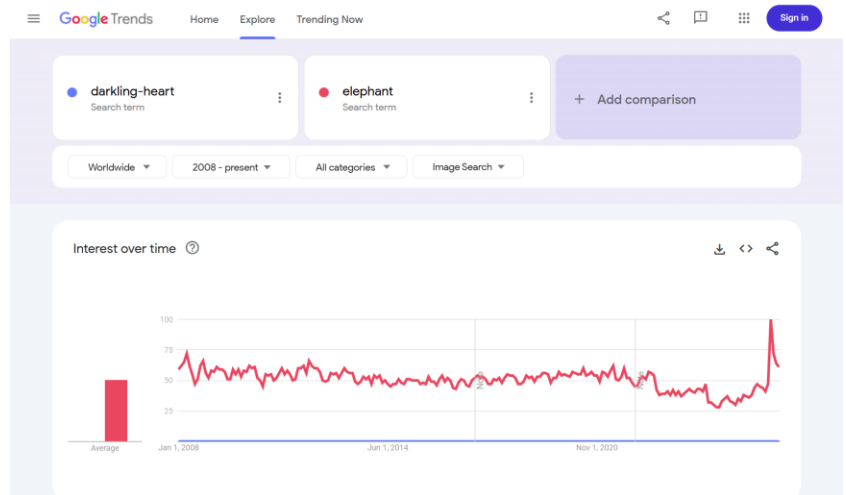


4. Google Trends: Image Search

Search: darkling-heart, elephant — Image search, all time: trampled by the elephant!

URL:

https://trends.google.com/trends/explore?date=all_2008&gpr_op=images&q=darkling-heart,elephant

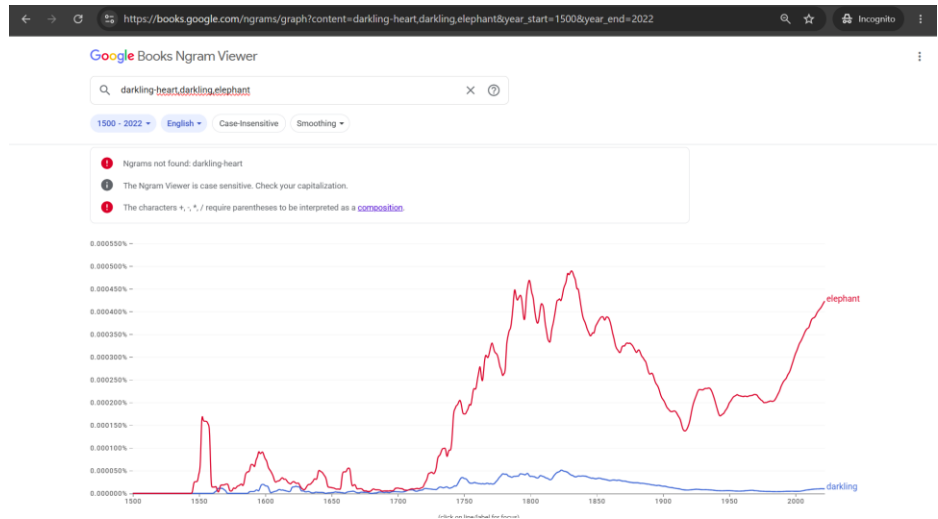


5. Google Books Ngram Viewer

Search: darkling heart, darkling, elephant — 1500–2022

URL:

https://books.google.com/ngrams/graph?content=darkling-heart,darkling,elephant&year_start=1500&year_end=2022



- f. Completes an incomplete category

The Unicode Standard currently includes the Sparkling Heart emoji but is missing its dark complement. The Darkling Heart would complete a natural pair analogous to existing light/dark emoji pairs such as Sun Face / Moon Face
- g. Is needed for compatibility with popular existing systems
 - N/A
4. **Factors for Exclusion.** These factors weigh against a proposal's inclusion in the Unicode Standard. Address each and provide evidence (cite with data to back up any claims) to show that your emoji proposal is not:
 - a. Already represented

No, users can approach the meaning through combinations of existing emojis but not express it precisely.
 - b. Overly specific

No, while there may be associations to specific literary genres or subcultures, the underlying concept of a shadowy, dark love is something that can be universally understood
 - c. Open-ended

No, adding the Darkling Heart does not imply a need to add other emojis to a sequence
 - d. Transient

No, while dark romance may be having a “moment” on BookTok, the word darkling dates to the 14th century and darkle has been in use since 1823

- e. Justified by an existing emoji

Tricky, because there is an obvious relationship with Sparkling Heart as proposed under “Completes an incomplete category.” We propose the inclusion due to its lexical foundation (darkle / darkling) and visual distinctiveness.

- 5. **Other information.** Any other information that would be helpful, such as design considerations for images.

- a. N/A